The Meaning of Life Across Scholarly Disciplines

Project Narrative

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Motivation

The question of how to live a meaningful life gets asked in philosophy departments, psychology labs, Sufi lodges, Buddhist monasteries, Confucian academies, Indigenous communities. Different centuries, different vocabularies. Same underlying problem. What struck me early is how little these traditions talk to each other. A psychologist measuring "meaning in life" with Ed Diener's satisfaction scales has almost certainly never read al-Ghazali's *Kimiya al-Sa'ada*. A philosopher working on eudaimonia may have no idea that *ikigai* has generated its own body of peer-reviewed research in Japan. The silos run deep.

I wanted to see those silos. Map them. And find out whether any bridges exist that the individual literatures don't acknowledge.

Process

Term Curation

Everything depended on the search terms. If I only used English-language psychology jargon, I'd get a psychology-heavy dataset and then conclude that psychology dominates. Circular. So I spent real time building a term list that could cut across traditions without pre-imposing structure on what it found.

I started with manual brainstorming. *Eudaimonia*, *phronesis*, *flourishing* from the Greek tradition. *Saada*, *falah*, *maqasid al-shariah* from Islamic thought. *Moksha*, *dharma*, *purushartha* from Hindu philosophy. *Ikigai* from Japan. *Ubuntu* from Africa. *Buen vivir* from the Andes. About 90 terms came out of that first pass.

Then I ran two rounds of vector-space discovery using the all-MiniLM-L6-v2 sentence-transformer. The idea was simple. Embed the existing terms, pull abstracts and keywords from OpenAlex for related queries, embed those, and measure which new terms clustered nearest to my seed list. The first round caught *self-determination theory*, *narrative identity*, *terror management theory*. Concepts I hadn't thought to include. The second round surfaced more niche vocabulary like *bodhisattva*, *hermeneutics*, *dialogical self*.

After both rounds I reviewed for structural gaps. A few jumped out. Anthropology was almost entirely missing, which was a problem since it's arguably the discipline most engaged with cross-cultural understandings of well-being. Subjectivity and phenomenological vocabulary were thin. And I'd transliterated Arabic terms (saada, falah, tawakkul) but left Chinese, Sanskrit, Japanese, Korean, and Hebrew terms in their original scripts, which OpenAlex can't search. I fixed all of these.

One decision shaped everything after it. I kept the term list flat. No pre-clustering by tradition. Whether *eudaimonia* belongs to philosophy or psychology is exactly the kind of question the dashboard should answer from the data. Imposing that structure beforehand would have compromised the analysis. The final list had 245 terms across 16 traditions, with a documented count per tradition so the coverage imbalance was visible.

Data Collection

I queried the OpenAlex API for all 245 terms, pulling up to 500 works per term. Each work came with title, abstract, publication year, journal name, and author institutional affiliations. The collection ran in batches of 50 terms to respect rate limits. After deduplicating by work ID the dataset held 129,672 unique scholarly works. About 77% had abstracts. The bulk of the data falls between 1960 and 2025.

Building the Classifier

This turned out to be the most consequential decision in the project. OpenAlex assigns every paper a field classification based on journal metadata and citation patterns. I tested it on my data and found serious problems. Papers about Aristotle's eudaimonia were tagged as Social Psychology. Papers on maqasid al-shariah ended up under

Accounting. One paper on ubuntu philosophy got classified as Computer Science, because the classifier confused the African philosophical concept with the Linux operating system.

So I built my own. Sixteen descriptions, one per tradition, each loaded with the names, concepts, and vocabulary that define how that tradition thinks about the good life. The Islamic Thought description references al-Ghazali, Ibn Sina, maqasid, tazkiyat al-nafs, falah. The Buddhist one covers the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, dukkha, nirvana, metta, karuna. I embedded these descriptions using sentence-transformers and compared each paper's title and abstract (70% weight) plus its journal name (30%) against all 16 anchors via cosine similarity. Papers where two traditions scored within 92% of each other got both labels. When the journal name was unreliable (eBooks platforms, metadata artifacts), the system dropped it and classified on content alone.

Validation against known test cases showed the classifier significantly outperformed OpenAlex on non-Western categories. It handled ambiguous cases like mindfulness, which legitimately straddles Buddhist Thought and Psychology, by assigning dual labels when scores were close enough.

Visualizations

The Network Graph

This is the centerpiece. A force-directed constellation where each node is a scholarly tradition and each edge represents papers bridging two traditions. I chose a network graph because the core question is relational. A bar chart can show that psychology produces more papers. It can't show that Buddhist and Hindu thought share 3,063 works between them, or that Anthropology reaches Indigenous traditions in ways no other discipline does.

The design renders traditions as glowing nodes against a dark background, sized by publication volume, colored by tradition. Edges glow gold when a node is selected. Hovering any node surfaces its top connections and paper count. Clicking a node highlights its edges and loads a panel of actual papers with links to OpenAlex. Clicking a connection bar narrows the panel to papers specifically bridging those two traditions. The heatmap alongside provides the full matrix of connection strengths, making patterns visible that the spatial layout might obscure.

The Animated Bar Chart Race

An animated chart plays through 1960 to 2025, showing traditions accumulate scholarship year by year. In the early decades, Western Philosophy and Christian Theology led. By the late 1990s, Psychology began overtaking everything, accelerating sharply after Martin Seligman's 1998 APA presidential address launched the positive psychology movement. A static chart can state that fact. The animation makes it feel like something that actually happened.

I paired the race with a streamgraph on the same page. The streamgraph shows the same data as flowing layers, each tradition's width representing annual output. Better for seeing volume trends. The race is better for ranking shifts. Together they tell the temporal story from two angles.

The Geographic Choropleth with Time Slider

A world map color-coded by research volume per country, with a yearly slider running 1960 to 2025. Dragging it forward shows countries entering the conversation over time. Indonesia lights up as Islamic studies grow. India brightens with Hindu scholarship. The map fills gradually from a handful of Anglophone countries toward something more global.

A second choropleth shows the dominant tradition per country. This reveals geographic clustering that the volume map alone can't capture. Psychology dominates the Anglosphere. Islamic Thought dominates Southeast Asia and the Middle East. Hindu Thought concentrates in South Asia.

Key Findings

Psychology leads with about 15,500 works. Under OpenAlex's classifier that dominance would look even more extreme, because papers about eudaimonia and ikigai get absorbed into psychological categories. Under the custom classifier the picture changes. Existentialism and Phenomenology accounts for 11,191 works. Hindu Thought for 10,744. Islamic Thought for 9,126. The conversation is more pluralistic than standard bibliometric tools suggest.

The strongest bridge in the dataset runs between Buddhist and Hindu thought at 3,063 shared works. Stronger than any connection within the Western academy. Anthropology functions as the most consistent bridge discipline. Existentialism turned out to be the unexpected connective tissue, linking to almost every other tradition in the network. Frankl, Heidegger, Buber, the phenomenological tradition generally. They connect to everything.

33.1% of papers received dual-tradition labels. A third of the scholarship lives at intersections. Two-thirds stays inside disciplinary walls. Geographically, the United States produces more on this topic than the next five countries combined.

Outlook

Going multilingual would be the most impactful extension. Adding Arabic, Chinese, Sanskrit, Japanese, and Korean search terms and querying databases that index non-English scholarship would transform this from a map of the English-language conversation into something closer to the actual global one. A larger language model fine-tuned on hand-labeled data would improve classification. Tracing actual citation links (OpenAlex provides these) rather than relying on co-occurrence would sharpen the network. And deploying it publicly with scheduled data updates would make it a living resource rather than a finished project.

AI Usage

I used Claude (Anthropic) throughout the project. It wrote the vector-discovery scripts, the API collection code, the classifier, and the Dash dashboard. It also drafted this writeup, which I revised. The research question, the methodological decisions (flat term list, custom classifier, which traditions to include), identifying gaps Claude missed (anthropology, subjectivity, non-Arabic transliterations), running the classifier, testing and debugging every component, and the overall design direction of the dashboard all came from me.